

I draw a blank!

Q. I have a Pentium III processor with a Compaq Presario 5000 installed with Windows Me. The problem I am facing is that some games, after being loaded to play, show a blank screen, but the sound works fine without any disturbances. The busy light on my CPU remains on throughout. In a few other games, the graphics appear on screen gradually. Please help.

Aditya Bajaj

Via e-mail

A The problem pertains to the display drivers (VGA drivers). In the Control Panel, double-click on System and then on the Device Manager button. Click on the plus (+) sign next to the display adapters—it should not be showing a yellow icon on it. If it does show an error icon on the display adapter, then you need to load the updated set of VGA drivers.

However, if the adapter is configured properly then the problem could be because you are using a low-end VGA card. In this case, the only option would be to upgrade the VGA card to the level required by the game. A GeForce MX or above should be more than adequate for most games.

Invisible Data

Q. A few days ago I had taken my home hard disk (a 40 GB, 7,200-rpm drive) to my college to copy some data. I had connected my home hard disk as Slave (CL) and copied around 2 GB of data to it, but when I checked the hard disk at home (connected as Primary), it didn't show the copied files, though the used up space reflected the size of those files. What should I do? Should I format my C drive and reinstall the OS? Or is there another way out?

There's another problem with my C drive: when I run Disk Cleanup, it doesn't clean the disk properly. It stops in between, at 'Compress old files'. CPU usage reaches the 100 per cent mark and it doesn't come down even when I cancel it—it remains in the 'Tasks Running', so I have to manually end cleanmgr.exe to make things stable. Any ideas about these strange problems?

Deep Ganatra

Via e-mail

A Problems while copying from hard disk to hard disk usually happen while performing Drag-N-Drop copy. It is very easy to drag the files to the wrong folder. So if you remember some of the filenames that you had copied, search for them in

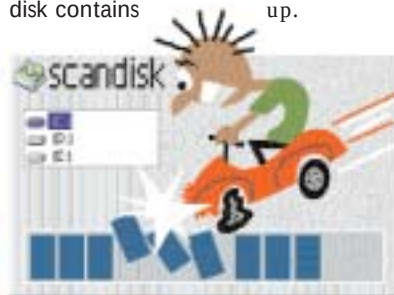
Scandisk scans tirelessly

Q. My PC has a P4 1.5 GHz processor, a 20 GB Samsung hard disk and an Intel 845 motherboard. My problem is that when I start the machine, it automatically runs Scandisk and also shows a message that the hard disk contains bad sectors. This is despite the fact that I shutdown the machine properly. But after completing the surface test, no bad sectors are found. Why is this happening? Please help me solve this problem.

Shubha Nambiar

Via e-mail

A Anytime a problem occurs while accessing the hard drive, Windows makes some entries in the registry. The next time you boot up the machine, Windows recognises the entries and takes preventative/corrective steps to



ILLUSTRATIONS: Mahesh Benkar

ensure less damage. Scandisk tries to detect the problem and update the registry entry properly. In your case, Scandisk, even after successful completion, is unable to remove the entry, hence Scandisk appears every time you boot up.

You could try disabling Scandisk manually in the msdos.sys file, but this would permanently disable Scandisk. It will not run automatically even in case of an error. So the safest bet is to reinstall the operat-

ing system.

Alternately, since you have a Samsung hard drive, you can download a diagnostic utility, SHDiag.exe, provided by Samsung on its Web site. In case this utility detects an error it can't repair, you should take your hard disk to the RMA centre for repairs.

your hard disk. Also ensure that the 'Show hidden files and folders' option is checked (Click on **Tools > Folder Options** or **View > Folder Options** depending upon the operating system installed).

As for your second problem, as time passes a lot of temporary files are created in the system, so it takes time to prepare a list of the unwanted files. If you feel that the machine hangs, run Scandisk with the Thorough option checked. The Thorough option checks the hard disk surface for physical damage. It would take some time to check but after the test is complete, the problem should be solved.

Cannot playback audio stream

Q. I have a Celeron 633 with 64 MB RAM and a 20 GB hard disk with four partitions. The primary partition (C:) has Windows XP Professional and Windows 98SE installed (in different folders); the last partition (F:) has Mandrake Linux installed.

In XP and Linux, video and audio files run well, but Windows 98 shows an error, 'Cannot playback the audio stream, no audio hardware is available or the hardware is not responding (Error =80040256)'; a little later the video starts without audio. How can I fix this?

Anoop Kumar Vaidya

Via e-mail

A You are facing this problem in Windows 98SE because its Windows Media Player (version 6.4) cannot play videos encoded with the newer codecs. To solve this, you need to install the appropriate codecs. The DivX codec is available at www.divx.com and the Nimo codec at <http://nimo.titanes.com/modules/mydownloads/>. You can even download the latest version of Windows Media Player from the Microsoft Web site.

Ruling the messages

Q. My company receives around 200-300 messages a day, which are distributed to the employees concerned through Postmaster. In case a virus in a message damages a system, we have to run Windows setup again on that PC. This obviously erases all the Message Rules set in Outlook Express.

Is there some way to back up Message Rules in Outlook Express so that they don't have to be recreated in case of a Windows reinstallation? Also, can one rule be applied to all the terminals on the network?

Sarita Sawant

Via e-mail

A Outlook Express does not provide any mechanism to export/import Message Rules. So there's no option but to